AI ACADEMY SOUTH AFRICA
Build bold AI Solutions for South Africa

The AI Academy South Africa is Meta's flagship capacity-building program designed to equip South African students, professionals, and startups with practical AI skills and tools. The program combines a startup competition and AI masterclasses to develop the next generation of AI talent in South Africa.

In partnership with DCDT

communications & digital technologies

Department:
Communications & Digital Technologies
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

AI Academy South Africa Pitchathon
Are you a South African startup or developer building an innovative solution with Meta's AI technologies?

Apply to the **AI Academy South Africa Pitchathon** for an opportunity to pitch your solution live, connect with investors and ecosystem leaders, and compete for $5,000 in equity-free funding.

Applications close on October 20, 2026.

Apply now

The AI Academy South Africa Pitchathon is a dedicated track for early-stage South African startups with working AI prototypes or products built using Meta's AI technologies and open-source models. Ten selected startups will pitch their solutions for a chance to win:

- $10,000 in funding (top 2 startups win $5,000 each)
- Fully-hosted access to Meta's AI Summit in Turkiye

The Pitchathon is open to early-stage startups based in South Africa that are developing practical and impactful AI solutions using Meta's AI technologies. Applicants should:

- Be a startup or founding team based in South Africa
- Have a working prototype or MVP that demonstrates clear technical potential.
- Have embedded at least one of Meta's AI technologies in their solution (For example, Llama, SAM, DINO, Muse, or PyTorch).
- Be solving a clearly defined problem with relevance to users, businesses, communities, or public institutions.
- Be available to participate fully in all required Pitchathon activities, including an in-person pitch competition.

Apply now

FAQ

What is AI Academy South Africa?

The AI Academy South Africa is Meta's flagship capacity-building program designed to equip South African students, professionals, and startups with practical AI skills and tools. The program combines a startup competition and AI masterclasses to develop the next generation of AI talent in South Africa.

What is the AI Academy South Africa Pitchathon?

AI Academy South Africa Pitchathon is an opportunity for South African startups and developers building innovative solutions with Meta's AI technologies to pitch their solutions live in **Johannesburg**, competing for $5,000 in equity-free funding and an invitation to pitch at Meta's AI Summit in Istanbul in November 2026. The winners will get: capital, visibility, and a route to a wider investor and partner audience.

Who can apply?

Applications are open to South African developers, startups, and teams building AI solutions using Meta's AI technologies.

The Pitchathon is intended for teams with an early-stage AI idea or a working AI product.

What happens after I apply?

Applications will go through a competitive selection process. Ten successful applicants will be invited to pitch their innovations live in South Africa.

What are the benefits of participating?

Selected startups will have the opportunity to:

• Pitch live in Johannesburg, South Africa.
• Gain exposure to investors and the broader innovation ecosystem
• Compete for equity-free funding
• Be considered for participation in Meta's Regional AI Summit in Istanbul, Türkiye in November 2026

What do the winning startups receive?

The top two pitchathon winners will each receive:

• US$5,000 in equity-free funding
• Meta advertising credits
• An invitation to attend Meta's Regional AI Summit in Istanbul, Türkiye, in November 2026

How do I apply?

Complete the online application by October 20, 2026. Eligible applicants will be reviewed through a competitive selection process, and shortlisted startups will be contacted.

Who do I contact for more questions?

If you have additional questions, please contact us using the **contact the organiser** link below.

Contact the organiser

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